

Poetry; “Evergreen” By
Oliver Baez Bendorf -
Poetry: “The Air Smelled
Dirty” By Marge Piercy
(52-54)



OLIVER BAEZ BENDORF: Biography

- Poet, Professor, librarian, & activist
- Iowa(1987)»Colorado
- 3 poetry books(*Considering the Rooster*[2024])
 - praised
- Many awards
- ‘Poems are bodies on the page’
 - Poems explore becoming & transforming
 - Intersecting nature, writing, & body



SELECTED WORK: “Evergreen” (2018) by Oliver Baez

Bendorf

What still grows in winter?

Fingernails of witches and femmes,
green moss on river rocks,
lit with secrets... I let myself
go near the river but not
the railroad: this is my bargain.

Water boils in a kettle in the woods
and I can hear the train grow louder
but I also can't, you know?

Then I'm shaving in front of an
unbreakable mirror while a nurse
watches over my shoulder.

Damn. What still grows in winter?

Lynda brought me basil I crushed
with my finger and thumb just to
smell the inside of a thing. So
I go to the river but not the rail-
road, think I'll live another year.

The river rock digs into my shoulders
like a lover who knows I don't want
power. I release every muscle against
the rock and I give it all my warmth.

Snow shakes
onto my chest quick as table salt.
Branches above me full of pine needle
whips: when the river rock is done
with me, I could belong to the evergreen.
Safety is a rock I throw into the river.
My body, ready. Don't even think
a train run through this town anymore.



Analysis of “Evergreen”: Nature and the Self

- Written in 2016[Vermont Studio Center]
- woods during winter —> meditates on living in despair
 - reflecting on a previous suicide attempt
 - Winter & forests —— contemplation of death
 - Shifts to positive
 - Like winter
- Evergreen trees keep green leaves(resilience)



I thank

you

for